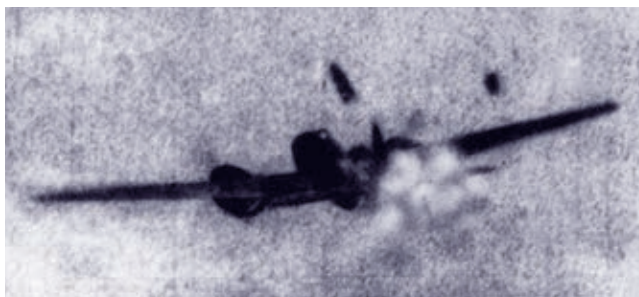


demoralization and exhaustion. But to win, the Luftwaffe had to break Fighter Command's resistance and, despite stretching it severely, the Germans never achieved that goal.

The turning point in the battle came on September 15, which is celebrated as Battle of Britain Day in the United Kingdom. Indeed, this was a day of heavy fighting, with Luftwaffe bombers and fighters arriving in two waves, the largest comprising almost 500 aircraft. It was also spectacular for Londoners – a good deal of the combat happened right above their heads. But RAF claims to have shot down 185 enemy aircraft were grossly inflated; the actual figure was probably 56, about twice the RAF's own losses. And the battle in no sense stopped – roughly the same number of German aircraft were downed on September 27.

But the continued ability of the RAF



LUCKY ESCAPE

This still taken by a gun camera shows what is probably the pilot of a Heinkel He 111 jumping out of his cockpit seconds before a direct hit. Despite their vulnerability, He 111s formed the core of the German bomber force in the Blitz.

Portsmouth, Cardiff, Liverpool, Glasgow, and Belfast, and inland industrial cities such as Birmingham

and Coventry. It was an unprecedented experiment, with the British people as guinea pigs. Would their morale hold or would social order fall apart in some catastrophic manner under the strain of bombardment? The result is now known, but at the time it could not be comfortably predicted.

The Blitz

From the first major daylight bombing of London – on September 7, 1940 – through to May 1941, Britain's cities were subjected to sustained aerial bombardment on a scale never before attempted. This was Douhet's concept of air war at last put to the test – an attempt to break civilian morale by using fleets of bombers to devastate enemy cities and industrial centers. Not only London was battered, but also ports such as Plymouth,

The scale of the bombing during the Blitz was later dwarfed by Allied bombing operations against Germany and Japan – in the heaviest raids of 1940–41 the Luftwaffe never dropped

KEEPING WATCH

Bofors anti-aircraft gunners keep watch over a seaside town on the southern coast of England as a friendly aircraft flies by. Sneak raids were an insoluble problem along the Channel coast.



GAS MASKS

Civilian gas masks differed from the military models (left), but their purpose was the same. However, gas bombs were not used by either side, chiefly for fear of retaliation.

